GLOSSARY

Glossary

Every musical word in the Handbook, in one line, with the page where it is explained.

a tempo back to the speed before p.79

accelerando (accel.) gradually faster p.79

accent a > over a note: start it more strongly p.76

acciaccatura a tiny note with a slash, crushed in as fast as possible p.85

accidental a sharp, flat or natural written before a note; it lasts until the bar line p.36

Adagio slow, at ease p.79

Alberti bass a broken chord in the left hand: low, high, middle, high (C G E G) p.149

Allegro fast and lively p.79

anacrusis an upbeat: notes before the first full bar p.62

Andante at a walking pace p.79

appoggiatura a tiny note without a slash; it leans, taking half the main note's time p.85

articulation how notes are joined or separated: slurs, staccato, tenuto, accents p.76

augmented triad a triad with 3 + 3 keys between p.110

bar a group of beats between two bar lines p.47

Baroque music of about 1600–1750: Bach, Handel p.156

bass clef the F clef: its two dots hug the line for bass F p.27

beam a thick line joining quavers or semiquavers into a beat p.62

beat the steady pulse you count p.47

binary form two sections, A B p.153

broken chord the notes of a chord played one after another p.139

cadence the last two chords of a phrase: musical punctuation p.136

cantabile in a singing style p.76

chord three or more notes played together p.107

circle of fifths the keys in a circle: go right, one more sharp; go left, one more flat p.102

Classical music of about 1750–1820: Haydn, Mozart p.156

clef the sign at the start of the staff that names one line p.27

coda an ending section; jump to it at "To Coda" p.68

compound time each beat is a dotted note and divides into three (6/8, 9/8, 12/8) p.59

crescendo (cresc.) getting louder, little by little p.73

crotchet a note worth one beat in 4/4 p.50

da capo (D.C.) "from the head": go back to the beginning p.68

dal segno (D.S.) "from the sign": go back to the segno p.68

diminished triad a triad with 2 + 2 keys between p.110

diminuendo (dim.) getting softer, little by little p.73

dolce sweetly p.76

dominant the 5th note of the scale, and the chord built on it (V) p.113

dot adds half the note's value p.53

duplet two notes in the time of three p.62

dynamics the signs for loud and soft: pp p mp mf f ff p.73

enharmonic two names for one key, such as F♯ and G♭ p.36

GLOSSARY · CONTINUED

fermata a pause: hold the note longer than written p.79

Fine "the end": after a D.C. or D.S., stop here p.68

five-finger position one finger on each of five keys in a row p.160

flat (♭) the very next key to the left p.36

form the plan of a whole piece, in letters p.153

forte (f) loud p.73

grand staff treble and bass staves joined by a brace p.27

hairpin a crescendo or diminuendo sign that opens or closes p.73

hemiola two bars of three felt as three bars of two p.65

homophonic a tune with chords underneath p.149

imitation another hand or voice copies the idea p.147

interval the distance between two notes p.39

inversion a chord with a note other than the root at the bottom p.116

key the scale a piece is built on, and its home note p.96

key signature the sharps or flats at the start of every line p.96

Largo very slow and broad p.79

leading note the 7th note of the scale, one key below home p.90

ledger line a short line for a note above or below the staff p.32

legato smoothly joined p.76

major scale tone, tone, semitone, tone, tone, tone, semitone p.90

major triad a triad with 3 + 2 keys between p.110

metronome mark ♩ = 76: 76 beats in a minute p.79

mezzo (m) "half": mp half soft, mf half loud p.73

Middle C the C nearest the middle of the keyboard, on a ledger line between the staves p.22

minim a note worth two crotchets p.50

minor scale the major scale on the same note with 3, 6 and 7 one key lower p.93

minor triad a triad with 2 + 3 keys between p.110

Moderato at a moderate speed p.79

modulation changing key during a piece p.151

monophonic one line alone p.149

mordent the note, its neighbour above (or below), the note p.85

motif a short idea of 2 to 6 notes that comes back p.145

natural (♮) cancels a sharp or flat p.36

octave from one note to the next of the same name: 11 keys between p.42

ornament a small sign for a quick group of notes around the main note p.85

pedal (sustain) the right pedal: notes keep ringing until you lift it p.82

perfect cadence V to I: a full stop p.136

phrase a musical sentence, often 4 bars p.145

pianissimo (pp) very soft p.73

piano (p) soft p.73

plagal cadence IV to I: the "Amen" p.136

polyphonic two or more tunes at once p.149

Presto very fast p.79

progression a trip from chord to chord p.141

pulse the steady beat underneath the music p.47

quaver half a crotchet p.50

rallentando (rall.) gradually slower p.79

GLOSSARY · CONTINUED

relative minor the minor key with the same key signature, a minor 3rd below p.93

repeat sign two dots and a double bar: play the bars again p.68

rest a silence of a set length p.50

ritardando (rit.) gradually slower p.79

Romantic music of about 1820–1900: Chopin, Schumann p.156

rondo A B A C A: the first idea keeps coming back p.153

root the note a chord is built on and named after p.107

rubato time stretched and given back, for expression p.65

scale the notes of a key in order, up or down p.90

semibreve a whole note: four crotchets p.50

semiquaver half a quaver p.50

semitone the very next key: no key between p.22

sequence the same shape repeated higher or lower p.147

seventh chord a triad with one more 3rd on top p.119

sforzando (sfz) one note made suddenly strong p.73

sharp (♯) the very next key to the right p.36

sight-reading playing music at first sight p.164

simple time each beat divides into two (2/4, 3/4, 4/4) p.56

slash chord C/E: the chord, then the bass note p.128

slur a curve over different notes: join them p.76

staccato a dot: short, detached p.76

staff the five lines and four spaces music is written on p.27

subdominant the 4th note of the scale, and the chord built on it (IV) p.113

swing pairs of quavers played long–short p.65

syncopation the stress falls off the beat p.65

tempo the speed of the beat p.47

tenuto a line: hold the note its full length p.76

ternary form A B A: out, away and back p.153

texture how many lines sound at once, and how they fit p.149

theme and variations one tune, changed each time it returns p.153

tie a curve joining two notes of the same pitch: one longer sound p.53

time signature top: how many beats; bottom: which note gets one beat p.56

tone two semitones: one key between p.22

tonic the 1st note of the scale: home p.90

treble clef the G clef: it curls round the line for treble G p.27

triad three notes stacked: play one, skip one, play one p.107

trill the note and its neighbour above, back and forth quickly p.85

triplet three notes in the time of two p.62

turn above, the note, below, the note p.85

twelve-bar blues I I I I · IV IV I I · V IV I I p.141

una corda (u.c.) the left (soft) pedal p.82

upbeat see anacrusis p.62

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